

Affirmative Case Construction

During prep time you will need to prepare a case that meets all the requirements and burdens that need to be addressed to have

Constructing a Fact or Value Case

Step 1: Define the key terms of the resolution or topic. Remember that the definitions you assign must be topical, meaning that they are what a reasonable person would use.

Step 2: Establish the criteria for the round. This is the decision rule that the judge will use to determine who wins the debate. In a fact round, using criteria such as “on balance” and “more often than not” are better than criteria that require you to prove something true in all instances. For value rounds, you will need to choose a “theme” or value that links all your arguments in support of your side of the resolution.

Step 3: Brainstorm potential arguments you want to try and get as many ideas on paper as possible in a relatively short amount of time, 4-6 minutes. Don’t worry about necessarily fleshing out the arguments. Once you have a good list 5-6+ ideas, quickly rank this list from the argument that best supports your position to the one that supports it the least.

Step 4: You and your partner can divide up the list to work on. The 2-3 best arguments will form your case, anything that remains will serve as your back up arguments. Because you never know what will happen once the debate starts, it is always good to have a couple of go-to backups. The 2-3 arguments that form for your case will need to be fully constructed contentions; with a main claim, warrants to support the claim, and impacts that explain the importance of the argument.

Step 5: Make sure that both debaters have a handwritten copy of the case on paper. Remember that no printed materials can be brought into the debate round itself.

Sample Framework

Opening remark (support)/greeting/thank you

Resolutional Analysis: Type and Definitions

Establish Criteria for round

Contention 1

Contention 2

Contention 3

Underview

Constructing a Policy Case

Step 1: Define the key terms of the resolution or topic. Remember that the definitions you assign must be topical, meaning that they are what a reasonable person would use.

Step 2: Establish the criteria for the round. This is the decision rule that the judge will use to determine who wins the debate. In policy debate, “net benefits” is the most widely used criteria. Simply stated net benefits means that the Affirmative team will win if there are a greater number of good things that will happen as a result, Negative wins if there are a greater number of bad things that will happen.

Step 3: Brainstorming on a policy topic is a little tricky. Most policy topics are asking you to identify the problem in the topic and create a plan to solve it. Here, you and your partner need to put together arguments and statements that follow the framework below. In a short amount of time you want to try and identify the problem, the solution for that problem, and a couple of idea of additional advantages. You want to aim to have this put together in 5-7 minutes.

Step 4: You and your partner can divide up the list of things that need to be worked on. Remember that the Significant Harms and Advantages are arguments that need a claim, warrants, and impacts. Inherency and Solvency are brief statements about how those points function in the debate. The plan has specific parts that need to be addressed.

Step 5: Make sure that both debaters have a handwritten copy of the case on paper. Remember that no printed materials can be brought into the debate round itself.

Sample Framework

Opening remark (support)/greeting/thank you

Resolutional Analysis: Type and Definitions

Establish Criteria for round

Significant Harm: What is the problem?

Inherency: Why is the problem getting worse or not being fixed?

Plan: How are we solving the problem?

 Action: Who is putting the plan into effect?

 Enforcement: Who is making sure it gets done?

 \$/TL: How much will it cost/When will it happen?

Solvency: How does the plan solve the Harm?

Advantages: Other benefits that will occur after plan is in effect

Negative Case Construction

The Negative team has a wide range of options at their disposal to defend their side in the debate. Offensive arguments made by the Negative team are called “off-case” arguments. Arguments made directly about the Affirmative’s case are called “on-case” arguments.

Off Case Arguments

1- Topicality: Topicality is an argument made by the Negative team that the Affirmative team has made an error in defining the key terms of the debate resolution.

Framework

- A. Interpretation: What is your interpretation of the word/phrase in question?
- B. Violation: Explain how the Affirmative has violated your interpretation. Provide your definition of the word and give a reason to prefer this definition over the Affirmative’s one.
- C. Standard: What standard should be used to judge the definitions? Some standards could include the following; common usage, reasonability, competitive equity, and fairness
- D. Voter: Here you explain that this is a voting issue.

2- Counterplan: A counterplan is an argument where the Negative team concedes that there is a significant harm but presents a competing plan for solving the problem. A counter plan has three key components to it; mutual exclusivity (meaning that the CP and Plan cannot be done at the same time), non-topical (meaning it must violate the resolution in some way), and that it is net beneficial (the counterplan must have more benefit than the plan).

Framework

- CP Text: What does the CP actually do
- Action: Who puts into effect? Same as regular plan.
- Enforcement: Same as regular plan.
- \$/TL: Same as regular plan.
- Non-Topicality: Explain how CP is non-topical
- Mutual Exclusivity: Explain how the CP is mutually exclusive.
- Advantages: Explain advantages that are independent to the CP.

3- Disadvantages: A disadvantage is an argument where the Negative argues that something unbeneficial will occur if the Affirmative’s plan is passed. The trick to a disadvantage is that the argument must be unique to the plan. In other words, if the negative consequence was going to happen anyway, it is not a reason to reject the plan.

Framework

- A. Uniqueness: Explain how the particular harm is unlikely to happen in the near term.
- B. Link: Explain which part of the plan causes the impact to occur.
- C. Brink: Explain how much of the Plan action must happen before the impact will occur.
- D. Impact: Explain in specific terms the negative consequences of the plan.